

Health Public Relations – Communicating for Wellness and Public Trust

1. Introduction to Health Public Relations

1.1 Definition and Scope of HPR

Health Public Relations (HPR) is a highly specialized strategic communication function dedicated to building, managing, and sustaining long-term relationships and reputation for organizations operating within the heavily regulated healthcare ecosystem.¹

Unlike general Public Relations, HPR requires a deep, specialized understanding of the unique complexities inherent in communicating about medicine, wellness, and scientific research.

The scope of HPR is broad, encompassing institutions across the entire healthcare spectrum. This includes hospitals and expansive health systems, pharmaceutical companies, medical device firms (MedTech), academic research centres, healthcare nonprofits, and governmental health bodies.¹

Success in this field demands more than just effective storytelling; it requires specialized infrastructure and, crucially, regulatory insight.¹

A core competency for the HPR practitioner is the ability to simplify complex scientific narratives without compromising accuracy.¹ Health breakthroughs often struggle to connect with the public due to technical jargon and widespread skepticism.³

The specialized HPR expert must effectively translate medical science into plain language that resonates both emotionally and logically with a diverse array of audiences, from patients and caregivers to investors and regulators. This translation process ensures that complex ideas are presented as relatable stories, cantering around real-world benefits such as improved diagnostics and enhanced patient outcomes.³

1.2 Differences between Health PR, Medical Marketing, and Public Health Communication

Health PR operates at a critical intersection, requiring careful distinction from its adjacent communication fields based on fundamental differences in intent, audience, and ultimate organizational goal.

Medical Marketing primarily focuses on the "sell," driving commercial demand for a specific product, service, or brand (e.g., a new drug or specialized surgical service). Its objectives are profit-driven, and its primary metrics revolve around Sales Volume and Return on Investment (ROI).²

Public Health Communication (PHC) is strictly focused on achieving public benefit. It utilizes consumer-cantered, science-based, and evidence-driven strategies to protect and promote the health of diverse populations.⁵

PHC campaigns often promote health-promoting behaviours or the use of specific health-related products, frequently distributing these products at free or reduced cost (e.g., nicotine replacement therapy or pedometers combined with walking campaigns) to overcome economic and psychological barriers to behaviour adoption.⁶ The ultimate goal of PHC is to benefit the product "consumers" and the public, aligning with population welfare.⁵

Positioning ANMS as a National Campaign

The Agenda Nasional Malaysia Sihat (ANMS), launched in 2020 by the Ministry of Health, is Malaysia's flagship public health movement designed to embed healthy living into everyday life. It goes beyond traditional health programs by adopting a Whole-of-Nation approach, mobilizing government agencies, NGOs, private sector, and communities to collectively promote wellness. As a campaign, ANMS positions health not merely as medical care but as a lifestyle and cultural practice, making it a national narrative that resonates with diverse stakeholders.

Communication and PR Strategy

From a communication and public relations perspective, ANMS functions as a multi-channel campaign that integrates mass media, social media, and community engagement. Success stories, wellness activities, and grassroots champions are amplified through digital platforms to create immediacy and emotional connection, while formal channels such as press releases, policy briefings, and sustainability reports provide credibility and accountability. The campaign's PR strategy emphasizes message pull-through—ensuring that the core message of “healthy Malaysians, healthy nation” is consistently reflected across all touchpoints, from ministerial speeches to community wellness events.

Stakeholder Engagement and Long-Term Positioning

ANMS also exemplifies strategic stakeholder management. For citizens, it offers relatable health programs and empowerment initiatives; for policymakers and regulators, it demonstrates compliance with national development goals; for media, it provides a steady stream of human-interest stories; and for NGOs and private partners, it creates collaborative opportunities. By balancing immediacy (social media advocacy) with depth (formal reporting), ANMS sustains public trust and positions itself as a long-term health communication framework. In this way, ANMS is not just a health agenda—it is a public relations campaign for national well-being, aligning Malaysia's health priorities with broader narratives of sustainability, resilience, and community empowerment.

Health PR (HPR), conversely, focuses on managing the institution's credibility and overall reputation, which is often referred to as maintaining the organization's *license to operate*.² HPR leverages earned media, builds thought leadership platforms, and engages in proactive stakeholder dialogue to position its executives and scientists as trusted experts.²

While HPR clients may include commercial entities (pharmaceuticals), the professional function dictates that HPR's ultimate objective must align closely with public benefit and the long-term defence of institutional trust, similar to PHC.⁵ HPR functions as the ethical mediator, ensuring that commercial motivations are filtered through a lens of objective data and verified claims.

The following table synthesizes the key differentiators among these three domains:

Table Title: Differentiating Health PR, Medical Marketing, and Public Health Communication

Domain	Primary Goal	Key Focus	Focus Audience	Regulatory Emphasis	Key Metric
Medical Marketing	Drive Commercial Sales/Profit	Product/Service Promotion	Consumers, Payers	Health Advertising Rules	Sales Volume, ROI
Public Health Communication (PHC)	Achieve Population Behaviour Change	Intervention Adoption, Education	Specific Populations, Community	Scientific/Evidence Standards	Behaviour Change Rates
Health PR (HPR)	Manage Institutional Reputation/Trust	Relationships, Credibility, Earned Media	Stakeholders, Media, Researchers	FDA, HIPAA, PDPA Compliance	Trust Metrics, Share of Voice

1.3 Why HPR Matters: Saving Lives, Shaping Behaviour, and Sustaining Trust

The importance of HPR is magnified by the high stakes inherent in healthcare. HPR is critical for several interlocking reasons, primarily centered on securing and defending public confidence.

Success in the complex biomedical and behavioural research enterprise requires public trust in the process.⁷ Historical abuses and scandals have often shaken public confidence, prompting governments to establish stringent regulatory oversight and performance standards for research protection programs.⁷

HPR is therefore fundamentally a regulatory compliance function wrapped in a communication strategy. Specialized agencies must possess a deep understanding of regulations such as FDA guidelines and HIPAA compliance.¹

The strategic importance of this is profound: any perceived non-compliance or failure to be transparent is not merely a legal or financial risk; it constitutes an immediate, devastating erosion of the very trust that HPR is built to sustain.⁷

Furthermore, HPR plays a vital role in shaping pro-health behaviour. By applying integrated communication campaigns that strategically combine mass media outreach with the distribution of practical health-related products, HPR effectively supports the larger goals of Public Health Communication.⁶ These campaigns promote specific positive behaviours related to disease prevention, safety, and injury protection.⁶

Finally, HPR provides the credibility advantage necessary to operate in the highly sensitive technology sector. In healthcare, where the reliability of technology solutions, patient privacy, and data security are paramount, credibility is recognized as a decisive competitive advantage.²

HPR builds credibility by ensuring that the company's story is consistent, evidence-based, and trustworthy. That credibility then becomes a competitive advantage—doctors and hospitals are more likely to adopt the technology, regulators are more confident in approving it, and patients feel safer using it.

PR works relentlessly to maintain this credibility by showcasing institutional expertise, managing reputation proactively, and fostering trust within the broader healthcare community. Trust in a healthcare entity, whether a hospital or a tech startup, must be earned through consistent, authentic communication and a demonstrable commitment to patient outcomes.⁹

2. Functions of Health PR

Health PR executes several core functions crucial for organizational stability and public safety, ranging from mass awareness campaigns to intensive crisis response.

2.1 Public Health Campaigns

HPR professionals are key strategists in developing and executing comprehensive public health campaigns. These campaigns are designed based on strong evidence of effectiveness, prioritizing the use of multiple channels—with mass media being a necessary component—combined with the provision of free or reduced-price health-related products.⁶ The strategic planning process identifies and promotes specific actions, such as utilizing over-the-counter nicotine replacement therapy for smoking cessation or distributing safety helmets for injury protection.⁶ The ultimate objective is to maximize the adoption and maintenance of sustained health-promoting behaviors.⁶

2.2 Crisis and Risk Communication

The healthcare environment is prone to crises that are diverse and high impact. HPR teams manage issues including ethical violations, fraud and financial improprieties, litigation, controversial policy changes, media investigations, natural disasters, and global pandemics.¹⁰

Effective crisis management requires a mandatory posture of readiness. This includes detailed crisis training, 24/7 on-call response capabilities, and formalized issues management partnerships embedded within the organizational leadership structure.¹⁰ In the public sector, the function extends to **risk communication**, which involves strategically managing high uncertainty and public anxiety during rapidly evolving health threats.¹² Global health bodies, such as the World Health Organization (WHO), prioritize effective, coordinated communication as integral to ensuring guidance is credible, timely, and integrated across all available channels.¹³

2.3 Promoting Healthcare Services and Institutions

HPR specializes in translating medical innovation into terms accessible to the public. For advanced technologies like Health IT or 3D dental imaging, PR professionals bridge the

communications gap by shifting the focus away from complex technical features toward real-world patient benefits, such as improved outcomes, better diagnostics, and enhanced patient experiences.³

A critical element of this function is thought leadership. HPR develops comprehensive strategies that position institutional executives and clinical leaders as reliable, go-to experts in the field.² This is achieved through the creation of evidence-based content—whitepapers, case studies, and corporate blogs—and strategic earned media placement, which collectively demonstrate domain mastery and foster trust within the healthcare community.²

2.4 Advocacy for Health Policies and Reforms

HPR often functions to facilitate complex advocacy and collaboration initiatives. A vital function is supporting **Public-Private Collaboration (PPC)**, which brings together private healthcare delivery organizations, the public health sector, and other critical stakeholders to address large-scale health challenges.¹⁴

HPR practitioners must act as partnership architects, supporting the government in building collaborative arrangements that endure. This requires mitigating conceptual and language barriers among different sectors and managing financial and public policy impacts.¹⁴ Furthermore, HPR supports governments in establishing robust monitoring mechanisms and meaningful regulatory measures necessary to ensure services provided through these collaborations meet established standards of care and contribute positively to health outcomes.¹⁵ Therefore, the success of this HPR function is often measured by the sustainability and positive outcomes of these multi-sector arrangements, demonstrating an institutional capacity to coordinate expertise and share risk across traditional boundaries.

2.5 Building Trust in Medical Research and Innovation

Trust in medical research and new health technology is not automatic; it must be actively built through transparent and empathetic communication. The process begins with articulating a clear, human, and purpose-driven narrative: defining the company's mission and how the innovation improves patient outcomes.⁴

This is where the principles of plain language become a core risk mitigation strategy. Jargon must be eliminated to overcome public scepticism and regulatory concerns.³ For instance, translating "disruptive AI-powered solutions" into the simple message, "We help doctors spot health problems earlier using smart technology," proactively defuses anxiety and builds confidence.⁴

Credibility is critically reinforced by securing third-party validation from respected sources, including clinicians, medical researchers, regulatory experts, and patient advocacy groups.⁴ When announcing strategic partnerships (such as between a technology firm and a major health institution), the PR focus must clearly detail the specific benefits to patients, which is proven to increase consumer trust metrics significantly.⁹

Because trust is fragile, a strong HPR strategy also mandates continuous, data-driven monitoring of media mentions, social conversations, and public sentiment to ensure alignment with public expectations and allow for immediate course correction when necessary.⁴

3. Key Stakeholders and Audiences

HPR requires a multi-layered stakeholder approach, managing relationships from the most specialized internal teams to the most vulnerable external communities.

3.1 Internal Stakeholders

Internal stakeholders are vital conduits of credible information. They include healthcare professionals, clinical staff, hospital management, government health agencies, medical affairs teams, and research and development (R&D) groups.¹

HPR must align communication across these regulatory, scientific, and administrative departments to ensure a unified and consistent organizational voice.¹ The WHO emphasizes the strategic importance of this internal alignment, noting that all employees must understand and use communications effectively to achieve overarching programmatic goals.¹³ The quality of external communication is inextricably linked to the coordination and consistency of internal messaging.

3.2 External Stakeholders

External audiences are diverse and include patients, families, and surrounding communities. Key mediators in the communication process are the media, particularly specialized trade media and healthcare journalists, who provide the crucial platform for earned media and credibility.¹

Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs) and patient advocacy groups serve as essential partners and validators.⁴ On a regional and global scale, international health bodies like the WHO, UNICEF, the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), and the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC) are critical stakeholders in coordinating health responses and policy.¹³

The current digital landscape necessitates effective, integrated, and coordinated communication across highly decentralized channels, ranging from traditional media relations to social and online platforms.¹³

The decentralized nature of modern communication increases the risk of inconsistent or inaccurate messaging. HPR's role is to act as the centralized quality control mechanism, ensuring that every message delivered, whether by a governmental ministry or a local community worker adheres to core principles of accuracy and organizational credibility.

3.3 Special Focus: Vulnerable Populations and Marginalized Communities

Communication planning for vulnerable and marginalized communities must adopt a progressive empowerment model rather than relying solely on one-way information dissemination. This approach involves actively inviting stakeholders to training programs on health and media literacy.¹⁷

Strategies targeting these groups must be contextually appropriate, utilizing localized, integrated channels, which can include traditional folk media, community media broadcasting towers, community websites, and personal media like cell phones and physical leaflets.¹⁷

Furthermore, HPR must support community initiatives, such as advocating for primary health-care units to monitor noncommunicable diseases (NCDs) in collaboration with civil society and empowering the formation of peer-to-peer and support groups.¹⁷

The use of participatory tools, such as digital storytelling, podcasts, and vodcasts, allows the community to co-create and disseminate knowledge, ensuring that communication reflects the community's lived experience and thereby maximizing trust and reach.¹⁷

4. Tools and Channels

HPR utilizes a complex blend of traditional, community, and digital tools to deliver persuasive and trustworthy health messages.

4.1 Health Campaigns

Successful health campaigns are strategic hybrids. They must incorporate a mass media component (e.g., radio, television) alongside the distribution of educational materials (posters, brochures, handbooks) and, often, the free or reduced-cost distribution of health-related products to facilitate behaviour change.⁶ These campaigns require comprehensive planning that integrates behavioural theory with practical logistical deployment.

4.2 Press Releases and Media Briefings by Ministries or Hospitals

For organizations like Ministries of Health (MOH) or specialized hospitals, press releases and media briefings are essential tools for delivering timely, accurate, and authoritative information.

HPR prioritizes earned media, a form of coverage secured in reputable trade publications and major news outlets because people are generally more likely to trust health messaging when it originates from a third-party source they trust, giving earned media a valuable credibility advantage over paid advertising.² HPR must ensure that spokespersons are medically or scientifically qualified, especially when communicating complex regulatory or scientific breakthroughs.¹

4.3 Community Outreach

Community outreach activities, such as free clinics, town halls, and school programs, are critical for delivering health messages at the local level. These activities must adhere to the Social Marketing principle of *Place*, ensuring that the location is convenient and accessible to the target audience, thereby minimizing logistical barriers.¹⁸

This may involve organizing first aid courses at schools and workplaces and facilitating discussions on vector-borne diseases like dengue fever within the community.¹⁷

4.4 Digital Health Communication (Apps, Websites, Telehealth Platforms)

The promotion of digital health technology requires HPR to prioritize the assurance of security and trust over the boasting of technical features. Telehealth platforms and health apps (e.g., Healow Open Access) must be promoted by focusing on benefits like instant appointment scheduling, 24/7 self-service through conversational AI, and convenient billing solutions.¹⁹

A successful PR strategy for Health IT must proactively emphasize its compliance with privacy regulations (e.g., HIPAA/PDPA), security protocols, and certifications.² Furthermore, HPR can integrate with advanced platform features, such as no-show prediction models¹⁹, to plan hyper-targeted, proactive communication interventions that address barriers before they arise.

4.5 Influencer and Celebrity Endorsements for Health Causes

While influencers, especially within patient communities on platforms like Instagram or TikTok, can be effective tools for increasing awareness, their use demands extreme ethical scrutiny.⁴ HPR must strictly ensure compliance with health advertising regulations to prevent the spread of misinformation or unsubstantiated claims. Any breach of this regulatory requirement risks critical damage to institutional trust, demanding a careful balance between the reach of the influencer and the credibility of the message.⁴

5. Ethical and Cultural Considerations

Ethical practice is foundational to HPR, recognizing that miscommunication or irresponsible representation can have life-threatening consequences.

5.1 Accuracy and Transparency in Health Information

HPR practitioners bear the primary ethical responsibility of balancing the provision of accurate and timely information with respecting the autonomy and privacy of individuals.²⁰ Crucially, ethical communication demands clarity.

The mandate to use plain language is an ethical imperative.²¹ Limited health literacy has a significant detrimental impact on public health outcomes.²³ Practitioners must therefore adopt and enforce structured guidelines (such as those established by the CDC and NIH) to ensure materials are organized logically for the audience, use carefully chosen, simple words, and make key information easy to find.²²

This commitment to clear communication serves as an antidote to institutional jargon and promotes equitable access to vital information.

5.2 Avoiding Fearmongering or Misinformation

Ethical communication requires communicators to consider potential unintended consequences and actively avoid stigmatizing groups or generating undue fear.²⁰ During health crises, the practitioner must manage media narratives carefully, fostering trust by being transparent about uncertainties while ensuring that all published content is credible, validated, and evidence based.⁹

5.3 Respecting Privacy and Confidentiality (HIPAA, PDPA Malaysia)

Data privacy constitutes one of the highest-stakes crises risks in contemporary HPR. Practitioners must be fluent in key global data protection frameworks:

- **HIPAA (Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act, US):** Sets the stringent national standards for protecting sensitive Patient Health Information (PHI) by US covered entities.
- **PDPA (Personal Data Protection Act, Malaysia):** Governs the collection, processing, and disclosure of personal data in commercial transactions within Malaysia.²⁴

The PDPA is being modernized to align with international frameworks like the European Union's GDPR.²⁵ This shift elevates the regulatory risk for HPR practitioners:

1. **Mandatory Compliance:** Organizations must comply with a **Cessation Notice** from a data subject who wishes to cease or prohibit the processing of their personal data for direct marketing purposes.²⁶ Failure to comply within a reasonable timeframe result in penalties.²⁶
2. **Increased Penalties and Notification:** Recent amendments include the mandatory notification of data breaches and maximum fines that have more than tripled (up to RM 1,000,000).²⁵ This makes data privacy preparedness the highest tier of crisis readiness, as a breach immediately negates all efforts in building institutional trust.
3. **Cross-Border Data:** Organizations must ensure personal data is not transferred to jurisdictions that have lesser personal data protections in place than Malaysia or Singapore.²⁴

Table Title: Comparative Analysis of Health Data Privacy (HIPAA vs. PDPA Malaysia)

Feature	HIPAA (US)	PDPA (Malaysia)
Jurisdiction	United States	Malaysia (Commercial transactions)
Protected Data Type	Protected Health Information (PHI)	General Personal Data (incl. sensitive data like health status)
Consent Requirement	Generally required for non-TPO uses (Treatment, Payment, Operations)	Required for collection, processing, or disclosure ²⁴
Right to Opt-Out	Right to restrict disclosures for treatment and payment	Explicit right to issue a Cessation Notice for direct marketing ²⁶
Key Recent Trend	Focus on enforcement and security safeguards	Modernization towards GDPR standards (mandatory breach notification, increased fines) ²⁵

5.4 Cultural Sensitivity in Health Messaging

Effective health communication cannot be culturally monolithic. HPR messaging must be carefully tailored to cultural contexts, which requires respecting traditional beliefs, societal taboos, and local hierarchies.²⁰ Utilizing community-based media and leveraging local leaders, as discussed in Section 3, are critical steps in ensuring contextualization and message acceptance.¹⁷

5.5 Ethical Dilemmas: Balancing Commercial Promotion with Public Health Needs

The HPR practitioner frequently faces the dilemma of balancing the commercial interests of private clients (e.g., pharmaceutical or health tech firms) with the overarching need for public health welfare.²⁰ Ethical decision-making requires the continuous assessment of whether promotion risks overstating claims or diverting public attention/resources from essential public health initiatives.

The ethical consensus dictates that public trust is the ultimate institutional asset.⁷ Therefore, ethical HPR must subordinate short-term commercial gains to the long-term, non-negotiable mandates of transparency, ethical rigor, and basing all promotion on rigorous, validated evidence.⁹

6. Theoretical Foundations

HPR campaign design relies heavily on established social science and communication theories to understand and influence health behaviour and public perception.

6.1 Health Belief Model (HBM)

The HBM provides a fundamental framework for explaining why individuals adopt or resist health behaviours, based on their cognitive assessment of a threat and the proposed action. HPR campaigns are structured around these central components:

- **Perceived Susceptibility and Severity:** Messaging must raise awareness of the individual's personal risk and the potential seriousness of the condition. For instance, campaigns addressing the H1N1 flu outbreak successfully used mass media to build upon existing perceptions of risk by situating messages within the HBM framework.²⁷
- **Perceived Benefits and Barriers:** HPR highlights the advantages of adopting the healthy behaviour (benefits) while explicitly minimizing the perceived costs, inconveniences, or discomfort (barriers) associated with the action.¹⁸
- **Cues to Action and Self-Efficacy:** Campaigns must provide triggers in a form of internal or external cues that prompt action and build the individual's confidence (self-efficacy) in their ability to successfully execute the recommended behavior.¹⁸

6.2 Social Marketing Theory

Social Marketing utilizes commercial marketing principles, specifically the 4Ps, to promote healthy lifestyles and behavioural changes. It provides the operational structure for applying the psychological constructs identified by the HBM.¹⁸

- **Product:** The "product" is the desired behaviour, knowledge, or health outcome (e.g., proper hand hygiene, using contraception, or engaging in a self-check procedure).¹⁸
- **Price:** This refers to the non-monetary and monetary costs associated with the behaviour.- HPR minimizes this cost (Price) by ensuring that participation in activities is free or low-cost, or by reducing logistical effort and time.¹⁸

- **Place:** The channel or location where the intervention is delivered. This must be accessible and convenient, often organized within the community (e.g., schools, local venues, or community news broadcasting towers).¹⁸
- **Promotion:** This is the persuasive communication strategy, utilizing an integrated mix of print, personal media, online media, and community outreach to raise awareness and reinforce behaviors.¹⁸

6.3 Two-Way Symmetrical Model

The Two-Way Symmetrical Model represents the normative ideal for public relations, emphasizing genuine dialogue, mutual understanding, and balance between the organization and its publics.²⁸ In health communication, this model is crucial for mitigating public scepticism, particularly concerning sensitive topics like vaccine hesitancy or institutional policies.

It requires HPR practitioners to deliberately frame organizational encounters and discussions to facilitate open, bidirectional dialogue, ensuring that the community's concerns and feedback influence institutional agendas and actions.²⁸ By allowing the public to genuinely influence the organization, this model transforms the communication process into a sustained trust-building practice.

6.4 Risk Communication Theory

Risk communication guides strategic messaging when the public is facing heightened uncertainty, fear, and anxiety, such as during the COVID-19 pandemic.¹² During such global health crises, audiences intensify their media dependency, actively seeking reliable information, clarity, and direction to manage stress and navigate rapidly evolving circumstances.¹²

Risk communication theory underscores the importance of coordinated, ethically grounded media practices that manage public perception, reduce misinformation, and support the effective adoption of protective behaviours.¹² While a crisis may demand rapid, one-way information dissemination, the subsequent recovery phase requires a strategic shift back to the Two-Way Symmetrical Model to rebuild trust by actively collecting and responding to community feedback.²⁹

6.5 Agenda-Setting & Framing Theories

- **Agenda-Setting Theory** describes how the media, through consistent coverage, prioritizes certain issues (e.g., infection rates, prevention guidelines) thereby influencing what the public perceives as the most important health threats (issue salience).¹²

HPR practitioners use this theory to strategically align media relations efforts with public health priorities, ensuring that critical issues like dengue awareness do not get "crowded out" by competing news agendas.

- **Framing Theory** focuses on how people orient their thinking about a problem by consciously selecting and highlighting specific aspects of an issue.³¹ HPR

professionals, particularly in advocacy roles, use framing analysis to interrogate how meaning is constructed around health problems.³¹

For instance, framing a public health nutrition problem can shift discourse from individual blame to the necessity of policy intervention, demonstrating the political dimension of health advocacy.³⁰

7. Case Studies and Local Context

Health PR is inherently localized, necessitating the study of regional contexts and specific organizational responses to real-world challenges.

7.1 Malaysia: COVID-19 Communication by KKM, Dengue Awareness Campaigns, HPV Vaccination Drives

The Malaysian Ministry of Health (KKM) employed aggressive mass media and digital strategies for rapid risk communication during the COVID-19 pandemic. A critical observation of this period involves the dengue paradox. Movement control measures (MCOs) instituted during the pandemic resulted in a significant reduction of dengue cases nationwide, with districts like Petaling reporting the highest reduction in incidence.³²

The subsequent HPR challenge involves preventing the public from assuming environmental vectors are permanently controlled. Post-crisis HPR must re-establish the salience of dengue awareness, using Agenda-Setting principles to overcome the public's attention being monopolized by the pandemic.

Malaysia's **HPV vaccination program** provides a strong example of successful multi-sectoral collaboration. The program achieved excellent uptake by integrating the effort between the Ministry of Health (MOH) and the Ministry of Education (MOE), utilizing the efficient school-based platform.³⁴

However, the COVID-19 school closures caused a massive disruption, leading to approximately 225,000 female students missing or having incomplete doses.³⁴ HPR was vital in designing and executing well-organized "catch-up" campaigns.³⁴

This required specialized communication to reassure parents, manage complex logistical coordination, and address any potential rise in vaccine hesitancy, highlighting the need for communication strategies to account for the paradoxical effects of crises.

7.2 Global Examples

Global bodies establish the standards for national communication strategies. The **WHO Communication Framework** provides comprehensive principles for ensuring that global health information, advice, and guidance is always actionable, accessible, relevant, timely, understandable, and credible.¹³

This framework guides the communication strategies of national agencies worldwide. Furthermore, historical campaigns, such as the **Red Cross disaster health response** and decades-long **anti-smoking campaigns in the US**, serve as classic examples of applying

foundational theories—like the Health Belief Model and Social Marketing Theory—to achieve sustained, large-scale behaviour change.

8. Skills and Competencies for Health PR Practitioners

The specialized nature of HPR requires a unique blend of scientific literacy, strategic thinking, and ethical sensitivity.

8.1 Health Literacy and Ability to Simplify Medical Jargon

The ability to translate complex medical jargon into simple, actionable language is the most critical technical skill for an HPR professional.³ Practitioners must be experts in applying structured **Plain Language** standards (such as the federal guidelines utilized by the CDC and NIH).²¹

Furthermore, the practitioner's competence extends beyond writing; they must advocate for organizational policies that create an environment enabling public awareness and coping abilities with low health literacy.³⁵ This transforms health literacy from a departmental task into an institutional quality standard, requiring a group effort by all medical staff, supported by clear educational material.³⁵

8.2 Crisis Communication and Risk Management

HPR practitioners must possess advanced expertise in developing comprehensive rapid response protocols, conducting extensive scenario planning for diverse crises (e.g., regulatory, ethical, or environmental)¹⁰, and leveraging risk communication theory to effectively manage public fear and anxiety during emergencies.¹²

8.3 Cross-Cultural and Multilingual Communication

Given the diverse global and regional contexts of health issues, professionals must possess the skills to ensure messages are not only accurate but also culturally accessible and relevant to varied linguistic groups.¹³ This involves tailoring content and selecting appropriate localized channels.

8.4 Collaboration with Medical, Scientific, and Policy Experts

The HPR practitioner operates as a crucial link between scientific research and public understanding. This requires the ability to work effectively and translate complex data alongside regulatory bodies, R&D teams, and medical affairs personnel.¹ They must also foster cooperation between physicians and patients for the purpose of defining shared treatment goals, improving overall health-related outcomes.³⁵

8.5 Empathy and Ethical Sensitivity in Messaging

Empathy is essential for developing messaging that authentically reflects the patient's journey, emphasizing empowerment and understanding.⁴ Ethical sensitivity guides the practitioner in being transparent, accountable, and continuously vigilant against potential negative outcomes, ensuring messaging avoids stigmatization or fearmongering.²⁰

9. Summary and Reflection

9.1 Recap of Key Concepts

Health Public Relations is a distinctive and essential field, differentiated from marketing by its primary focus on credibility and relationship management, and from public health communication by its institutional client base and regulatory constraints. HPR requires practitioners to possess specialized knowledge in crisis management, regulatory compliance (HIPAA/PDPA), and collaboration with scientific experts.

Success in campaign design hinges on the strategic application of theory, specifically the Health Belief Model and Social Marketing's 4 Ps, while maintaining ethical rigor through principles of transparency, cultural sensitivity, and mandatory Plain Language use.

9.2 Reflective Prompt: “How can health PR balance public trust with institutional interests?”

The central tension in HPR is often perceived as the conflict between the organization's pursuit of success (whether commercial or political) and the public's need for accurate, unbiased information. The conclusion of this specialized field is that for any health institution, public trust is the most critical institutional interest and the fundamental prerequisite for continued operation.⁷

The balance is therefore achieved not by compromise, but by the strategic decision to subordinate short-term commercial gains to the long-term, non-negotiable mandate of ethical conduct, transparency, and patient welfare.⁹ When PR prioritizes the patient's journey and validates claims with evidence, institutional interests are naturally served through enhanced credibility and sustainability.